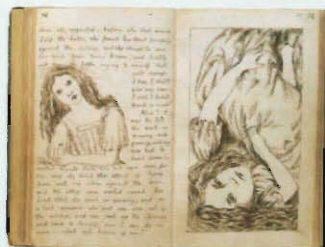


Fantasy stories

Until the mid-19th century, most of the stories written for children were concerned with the teaching of morals and good behaviour. However, the enormous success of Hans Christian Andersen's fairy tales encouraged many writers to produce wild fantastic stories which celebrated the imagination above all else.



Alice in Wonderland

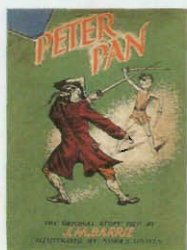
Written in 1865, English author Lewis Carroll's (1832–98) fantasy revolutionized children's literature with its fantastic plot, bizarre characters, and absence of any moral. The half dream, half nightmare world that Alice encounters when she plunges down the rabbit hole shows the limitless possibilities of the fantasy story.



Tenniel illustration of the Mad Hatter

Peter Pan

English author JM Barrie (1860–1937) originally wrote *Peter Pan* as a play in 1904. Peter, a motherless half-magical boy, takes the Darling children to Never Land.



Peter Pan

Wonderful Wizard of Oz

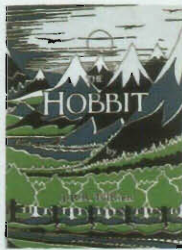
American author L. Frank Baum (1856–1919) wrote this fantasy in 1900. Dorothy is carried by a whirlwind out of Kansas to the magical Land of Oz, where she befriends the Scarecrow, Tin Woodman, and Cowardly Lion. In 1938, it was made into a popular film, ensuring that people world-wide know the story, even if they have never read the book.



Still from the 1938 film of *The Wizard of Oz*

The Hobbit

JRR Tolkien (1892–1973) published the tale of the Hobbit, Bilbo Baggins, in 1937. The trilogy that followed it, *The Lord of the Rings*, is one of the most popular stories ever published.



The Hobbit

Adventure stories

The 19th century saw the beginning of great adventure stories for children. The books celebrated bravery, daring, and excitement, although the heroes were often boys rather than girls. Some books, such as *Treasure Island*, described imaginary lands while others, such as *Huckleberry Finn*, were about adventures close to home.



Huck and Jim

Treasure Island

Scottish author Robert Louis Stevenson (1850–94) told a story of piracy. The tale is told by Jim Hawkins, who acquires a map showing hidden pirate gold. He has to defeat the pirates before he can claim the treasure.

Huckleberry Finn

American author Mark Twain (1835–1910) set his novel on the banks of the Mississippi River. One of its themes, black slavery, is illustrated by Huck's friendship with the runaway slave Jim.



A scene from the 1950 film of *Treasure Island*

School stories

School is part of children's experience, and often features in literature. The first and most famous school story was called *Tom Brown's Schooldays* (1857) by Thomas Hughes (1822–96). It was based on the author's own time at boarding school in England. Today's school stories usually reflect the experiences of most children.

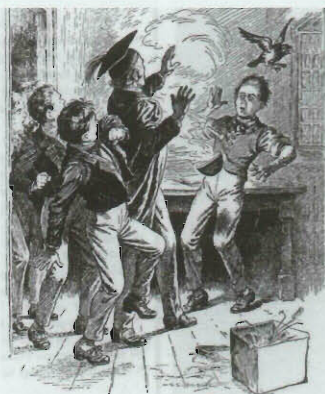
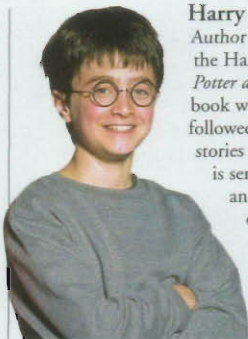


Illustration from *Tom Brown's Schooldays*



Harry Potter

Author JK Rowling published the first in the Harry Potter series in 1997, *Harry Potter and the Philosopher's Stone*. The book won several literary awards and was followed by equally popular sequels. The stories centre on Harry, an orphan who is sent to live with his aunt and uncle and discovers the Hogwarts School of Witchcraft and Wizardry. By 2002 the series had sold 100 million books in 46 languages.

Daniel Radcliffe played Harry Potter on screen.

Family stories

Children's literature often takes as its theme family life. Stories of family life date back to the 19th century; one of the first was *Little Women* (1869) by Louisa May Alcott. Today's family-based stories look at the difficulties that children may experience, such as divorced parents, bereavement, or abuse.

Little Women

Louisa May Alcott's (1832–88) novel about life in a small town in New England, was one of the first books that presented children in a realistic fashion. The story of the March family, Meg, Jo, Beth,

Amy, and their mother, Marmee, was in part autobiographical. It inspired many other American writers to produce stories about family life. Alcott wrote several sequels to *Little Women* including *Little Men* and *Good Wives*.

Roald Dahl

British author Roald Dahl (1916–90) is known for his fantasy stories, which include *James and the Giant Peach* (1961), *Charlie and the Chocolate Factory* (1964), *Matilda* (1988), and *The BFG* (1989). His popularity is partly due to his skill in describing adults' frightening peculiarities in such a way as to make them laughable.



A scene from the 1949 film of *Little Women*